

## Culture, Ideology, Morality, and Religion: Death Changes Everything

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The human quest for immortality is as old as the human awareness of death. Throughout the ages, human beings have striven to transcend their inevitable end of life that awaits them and achieve immortality, be it through myth and religion, science and medicine, or family and work. In this chapter, we consider how the reality of death changes the way human psychological motives operate. Relying on terror management theory (TMT; Greenberg, this volume; Greenberg, Pyszczynski, & Solomon, 1986), we argue that humanly constructed meaning systems, such as culture, ideology, morality, and religion, serve important death-denying functions. Of course, these systems also function to solve practical problems. Understanding how the world works provides clues as to what to do to get what one needs and wants. However, TMT posits that the human awareness of death adds urgency to the way humans hold on to these sources of meaning and changes the sorts of meanings that people seek. We start with a brief overview of TMT and a discussion of how culture, ideology, morality, and religion are affected by awareness of mortality. We then address recent conceptualizations that cast the problem of death as a specific instance of a more general threat, and argue that awareness of death is a unique force for humankind—one that changes the pursuit of meaning, value, and security in ways that affect the functioning of culture, ideology, and religion.

### *The Meaning-Making Animal Faces Its Mortality*

Although ants, bees, and chimpanzees are all social animals, only human beings are cultural animals. Only human beings are meaning-making animals that live their lives embedded in a universe of symbols, ideas, and values created by other humans. TMT was developed, in

part, to explain the psychological functions served by these cultural conceptions of reality and the values they specify for appropriate human conduct. From the perspective of TMT, people use the meaning systems they learn from their cultures, referred to as *cultural worldviews*, to shield themselves from the anxiety that results from awareness of the inevitability of death. To get this protection, people must believe they are living up to the standards of value espoused by their culture, thus acquiring self-esteem in the short term, and literal or symbolic immortality in the long term. For one's worldview and self-esteem to effectively fend off anxiety, people must maintain faith in these conceptions. Because worldviews and self-concepts are humanly created ideas that often bear little relation to observable aspects of nature, they can be maintained only if others share them. Those who share one's worldview increase confidence in it, and those who do not undermine confidence (for a review of TMT research, see Greenberg, this volume).

Cultural worldviews are shared meaning systems that provide a theory of existence that gives meaning to life and standards of value that are guides for appropriate behavior and yardsticks against which people's value can be assessed. Maintaining faith in one's worldview and living up to its standards manages anxiety by imbuing life with meaning and oneself with value, thus opening the door to the literal immortality promised by the religious aspects of the worldview and/or the symbolic immortality that results from being a valuable part of an eternal entity greater than oneself. The term ideology is often used interchangeably with the term worldview. For present purposes, we used the term ideologies to refer to the aspects of cultural worldviews that provide a moral and rational basis for social, political, or economic systems and prescribe how members of that system should behave (Jost, Fitzsimmons, & Kay, 2004). Ideologies are the most central and highly valued aspects of most people's worldviews. That is, they contain the most important core religious and/or secular elements of the belief system,

which are revered and often viewed as “sacred truths” that are beyond debate. This is especially true when the ideology is believed to come directly from an omniscient and omnipotent deity. Conversely, especially revered secular elements of worldviews are often given sacred status (e.g., the U.S. Constitution), and the leaders responsible for these elements are often treated with god-like reverence (e.g., the American founding fathers). This link between ideology and the supernatural dimension is one of the central themes of this chapter.

Most popular contemporary theories of ideology, morality, and religion are primarily social in nature. They emphasize the role these institutions play in promoting smooth functioning of groups. Both system justification theory (Jost & Banaji, 1994) and social dominance theory (Sidanius & Pratto, 1999), for example, conceive of ideology as a motivated, system-serving belief system that legitimizes and maintains the current social order. Haidt (2007) posits that moral intuitions evolved to facilitate intra-group harmony, inhibit intra-group conflict, and bind groups together against rivals. Many recent theories similarly view religious belief as functioning to bring people together and encourage intra-group cooperation (e.g., Bloom, 2005; see also Park & Edmonson, this volume). Although we acknowledge the role of ideology, morality, and religion in promoting social cohesion, TMT suggests an additional function of these cultural institutions that dramatically changes the way people relate to them.

### *The Birth of Ideology, Morality, and Religion*

Cultural worldviews probably began as attempts to answer practical questions about how the world works that early humans could use to meet their needs and navigate through life – explaining how to find food, stay warm, and relate to others. Meaning systems are, by definition, social in that they are ways of sharing information among people. Relationships among people were no doubt an important topic of the earliest meaning systems. Even before this, primitive

moral intuitions were evolving that, as Haidt (2007) suggests, helped maintain social cohesion and minimize conflict. With the emergence of more sophisticated intellectual capacities and language, these moral intuitions were verbalized and codified into cultural norms and values, and then into comprehensive meaning systems into which these norms and values were embedded.

The emergence of the awareness of death was presumably a seismic event. Our ancestors needed to manage the potential for terror that resulted from their dawning awareness of the harsh reality of nature – that all living things eventually die. From this point on, meaning systems had to do more than simply guide action and maintain group cohesion – they became part of the emerging terror management system. The explanations of the workings of the world were thus expanded to imbue reality with supernatural powers. Deities were invented who could control nature and grant immortality to otherwise mortal humans. The emergence of gods and religions changed the dynamics of the moral intuitions and social norms used to control behavior.

Probably because of the human tendency to anthropomorphize and imagine that the gods thought much like they did, people created deities that granted immortality only to those who believed in them, followed their commands, and stayed in their good graces. This also led people to impute their own moral intuitions to the gods, who were assumed to use them as standards for judging who was worthy of immortality. Thus the regulation of moral behavior was turned over to all-powerful deities who granted immortality only to those who behaved in a moral manner and moral thought and behavior took on the added function of managing the newly emerged potential for existential terror. The fear of negative social consequences our pre-human ancestors experienced when they violated their moral intuitions was given further power by newfound fear of losing the immortality that could be granted only by the gods.

Because moral behavior became the major criterion for admittance to the afterlife by the deity, moral virtue took on added value and became the pre-eminent value for most cultures. This explains why moral values are so highly emphasized by most parents and other important socializing agents of the culture. Consequently, they are most people's primary basis of both self-esteem and evaluations of others (for a discussion of how the anxiety-buffering functions of worldview and self-esteem emerge out of early attachments and later socialization, see Arndt, this volume). In line with this view, Skitka, Bauman, and Sargis (2005) provided a broad range of evidence supporting the special status of moral beliefs in social judgments.

Consistent with the death-denying function of morality, research has shown that terror management processes affect reactions to violations of all five of Haidt and Graham's (2007) moral foundations (for a review, see Kesebir & Pyszczynski, in press). Many studies have shown that mortality salience (MS) leads people to rate moral transgressions based on the harm/care foundation (e.g., a doctor who amputates the leg of the wrong patient) as more severe and to recommend harsher punishment for the transgressors (Florian & Mikulincer, 1997). Other studies have shown that MS intensifies reactions to violations of the fairness dimension, for example, by increasing derogation of the victim of a random tragedy (Landau et al., 2004); conversely, learning about severely injured innocent victims elicits more death-related cognitions than learning about victims responsible for their condition (Hirschberger, 2006). In addition, when justice concerns are salient, MS increases support for violence even when the expected utility of violence is low, increases the appeal of justice-based arguments for military action, and increases the desire for justice, which mediates the link between death thoughts and increased support for military action (Hirschberger, Pyszczynski, Ein-Dor, & Kesebir, 2011). A multitude of TMT studies show that MS increases ingroup/loyalty in the form of both ingroup favoritism

and outgroup hostility. MS also increases support for leaders who proclaim the unique value of the ingroup (Cohen, Solomon, Maxfield, Pyszczynski, & Greenberg, 2004).

Death concerns are also at play in various aspects of the purity/sanctity dimension of morality. MS increases the intensity of reactions to disgusting stimuli and viewing pictures of bodily waste increases the accessibility of death-related thoughts (Goldenberg, this volume). The very first demonstration of the MS effect, showing that reminders of death lead to higher bond recommendations for a woman arrested for prostitution (Rosenblatt, Greenberg, Solomon, Pyszczynski, & Lyon, 1989), can be viewed as an instance of increased punitiveness toward a violator of the purity/sanctity dimension. Research demonstrating that MS increases belief in an afterlife, increases death thought accessibility when one's religious beliefs are challenged, and increases distress when using a crucifix in a disrespectful way provides additional converging evidence of the role of death concerns in the purity/sanctity dimension (Vail et al., 2010).

### *Keeping Faith in an Invisible World*

Because terror management through religious beliefs resides in an imagined invisible world that cannot be experienced through normal sensory channels, the anxiety-buffering power of worldviews, and the deities and moral principles they contain, are especially dependent on their acceptance by other people. It takes a village to maintain faith in things that cannot be seen. The emergence of immortality-granting gods increased the need for group solidarity and consensual beliefs. Although there are certainly other reasons people are motivated to maintain cohesive groups, the human invention of death-denying immortality systems greatly increased the urgency of these motives. Consistent with this view, research has shown that when interviewed in front of a funeral home, people exaggerate the extent of social consensus for their attitudes, especially when they hold unpopular opinions on the issues (Pyszczynski et al., 1996).

Indeed, archeologists have found evidence of large-scale human settlements replete with religious temples and images at Göbekli Tepe in Turkey, dating back 11,500 years, well before any evidence of agriculture or domestication of animals (Symmes, 2010). This suggests that the widely shared view that civilization resulted from the invention of agriculture might have it backwards. The motivation to please the gods who provided access to immortality may have brought people together into larger settlements to build temples, and the need to feed these larger groups may have accelerated the emergence of other aspects of culture, such as agriculture and domesticated animals (Solomon, Greenberg, Pyszcynski, Schimel, & Arndt, 2004).

The invention of deities probably also increased the power of those who were believed best able to communicate with this invisible world and persuade the spirits to look kindly on their followers. Priests and shamans were able to wield great power within their groups because of their alleged connections to the guardians of immortality and because of their “practical knowledge” of how to please the gods. These religious leaders either assumed great power or were closely aligned with secular leaders who were believed to be chosen by the gods for their leadership roles. In many cases, the leaders were believed to be gods themselves, as in the case of the Egyptian pharaohs and Japanese emperors. This merger of church and state provided a ready explanation and justification for the power wielded by the elite. Thus the death-inspired invention of gods and consolidation of supernatural and political power provided a potent incentive for system-justifying behavior: doubting the righteousness of the system put one’s literal immortality in jeopardy. A similar dynamic probably occurs when one questions the secular aspects of one’s culture, which puts one’s symbolic immortality in jeopardy.

*Death Does Not Necessarily Bring Out the Worst in People*

TMT does not imply that existential threats inevitably lead people to justify the status quo, as some have argued (e.g., Jost, Fitzsimons, & Kay, 2004). From our perspective, system-justifying behavior is motivated by the terror management function that some but not all political systems serve – for some but not all people. This suggests that an important determinant of whether or not people are motivated to justify the systems under which they live may be the extent to which these systems meet their terror management needs. People would be expected to justify systems only to the extent that the systems are effectively providing the meaning, value, and hope of immortality needed to manage their existential fears. When a system is believed to deny these resources, the motivation to overthrow it grows. Of course other factors, such as hope that such rebellions will be successful, are also needed for the motivation for change to lead to concrete action. This confluence of forces may be responsible for the “Arab Spring” of 2011 in the many Middle Eastern countries undergoing rebellions against corrupt leaders.

The fear of death leads people to seek protection wherever they can most readily obtain it. TMT posits that people construct their own worldview by combining elements of the diverse ideas, values, and experiences to which they have been exposed and that the extent to which this involves wholesale introjection of the ideas and values of powerful others or a thoughtful process of self-creation varies from person to person (Pyszczynski, Greenberg, & Goldenberg, 2003). The raw materials from which individualized worldviews are constructed reflect thousands of years of human thought, experience, hopes, and dreams, distilled through the socializing forces of each individual’s life. Worldviews are likely to be especially complex, multi-faceted, and conflicted in multi-cultural societies with heavy exposure to the human diversity.

Diverse research traditions suggest that an important determinant of which worldview element a person will use when in need of existential protection is the accessibility of the various

elements (Higgins, 1996). Highly valued or central aspects of one's worldview are likely to be chronically accessible and thus especially likely to guide responses to MS. A host of studies show that individual differences in political orientation predict the direction of responses to death reminders. For example, Pyszczynski et al. (2006) found that MS increased politically conservative but not liberal Americans' support for the use of extreme military tactics to fight terrorism, and Hirschberger and Ein-Dor (2006) found similar patterns among Israelis. Recent priming experiences temporarily increase the accessibility of worldview elements, thus affecting the specific response to existential threat. Research shows that priming the values of tolerance, compassion, and secure attachments all influence responses to MS, sometimes reversing the direction of effects found in the absence of such priming (Kesebir & Pyszczynski, in press).

It also seems likely that some worldview elements are more useful for safety and security than others. Elements of worldview and self most associated with security are probably held with greater conviction. Worldview elements closely tied to literal immortality, such as those involving gods, morality, and afterlife may be especially likely to be used to manage existential anxiety. Thus people may be most motivated to justify systems they view as sacred. Thus right wing authoritarians and religious fundamentalists, who construe their ontological beliefs as sacred and inviolate, are especially likely to respond to MS with hostility toward different worldviews (Motyl & Pyszczynski, in press). Rothschild et al. (2009) found that priming the value of compassion led fundamentalist Christians and Muslims to decrease support for hostilities against each other only when these values were presented as part of their sacred religious texts. Research has also shown that construing natural things (e.g., water) as sacred reduces the increase in worldview defense that MS otherwise produced (Kesebir, Chiu, & Pyszczynski, 2011).

In sum, research to date strongly refutes claims that existential threat inevitably leads to a conservative or system-justifying shift. Worldviews are too complex and people acquire security in too many ways for a simple unidirectional response to threat to be useful. The emerging picture is that of a highly flexible system in which both chronic and momentary salience of worldview elements, along with the security value of each, determines how people protect themselves from existential threat.

### *The Utility of Illusion*

The dawning awareness of death, and the invention of a supernatural dimension to make death less frightening, also changed other aspects of the way people understood their world. An accurate understanding of reality is usually the best guide for efficacious action to meet one's needs. In a world without fear, people might indeed approximate Heider's (1958) ideal of the naïve scientist, dispassionately gathering information to be objectively processed to obtain the most accurate understanding of reality possible. However, in a world where one of the few certainties is that one will die, with uncertainty regarding when, how, and what it will be like, beliefs that fit closely with observable facts about death may be too painful to be accepted. This may have been a major impetus for the emergence of self-deception in human thought.

Of course there are many reasons for people to shield themselves from the truth. Self-deception to maintain self-esteem, cognitive consistency, belief in a just world, feelings of relational security, and faith in one's worldview are all well known in the social psychological literature. Interestingly, these are all motives that research has shown to be affected by terror management concerns (Greenberg et al., 2008). If effective attainment of what is needed for survival and reproduction were all that mattered, there would be little impetus for distorting one's perceptions of oneself or one's environment, because this would more often than not

undermine one's chances of meeting one's needs. Perhaps self-deception is functional because it increases confidence and encourages risk-taking that is not justified by an accurate assessment of one's skills and the situation one is facing. But such distortions would more often produce negative outcomes, and if negative outcomes are more potent than positive ones (Baumeister et al., 2001), such deviations from accuracy would be discouraged. However, if there are powerful advantages to high self-esteem, cognitive consistency, and these other psychological motives beyond the pragmatics of achieving concrete goals, then deceiving oneself to achieve these states would be adaptive. TMT suggests that the role these motives play in managing existential terror provides that incentive. Although an accurate understanding of reality is useful when something can be done to produce a favorable outcome, when there is nothing that can be done to alter one's fate, the benefits of fanciful illusions may be much greater than the rewards for accuracy.

### *Summary*

People need meaning, morality, religion, and social connections for many reasons. As many have argued, thinking is indeed for doing. An accurate understanding of the workings of the world greatly increases one's chances of getting what one needs and wants. Moral behavior helps maintain social harmony, inhibits intra-group conflict, and binds people together to fend off enemies. And people need people to accomplish most of the important tasks of living; neither survival nor reproduction can be accomplished on one's own. The central point of TMT is that awareness of death changes the way these and many other motives operate. In addition to their original function of solving practical problems, human systems of meaning, morality, and religion took on death-denying functions that added urgency to them and changed the end states toward which they directed behavior. Social connections and coalitions with people who share one's meaning system are needed to maintain certainty and faith in these protective meanings.

### *Alternative Conceptions of Existential Motivation*

Over the past decade, alternatives to TMT have been proposed that seem to take death out of the existential equation. These alternative theories argue that the reason thoughts of death produce the effects they do has little or nothing to do with the problem of mortality, per se. Rather, it is argued that people are primarily motivated to seek meaning (Heine, Proulx, & Vohs, 2006), certainty (McGregor, Zanna, Holmes, & Spencer, 2001; van den Bos & Miedema, 2000), or social coalitions (Kirkpatrick & Navarrete, 2006), and that thoughts of death are upsetting because they threaten these motives. These alternative conceptualizations pose a “chicken or egg” sort of question: Do people seek meaning to protect themselves from fear of death, or is death frightening because it threatens meaning? Do people seek certainty because certainty regarding one’s protective beliefs is needed for their effective functioning, or is death threatening because it threatens certainty? Do people seek belonging and social coalitions because they reduce the fear of death, or is death threatening because it undermines social connections?

Although these alternative accounts emphasize different aspects of human experience as primary, they converge on the view that the problem of death is simply a specific instance of a threat to a more basic human need. This fits well with the longstanding tradition in psychology, and science in general, of explaining diverse phenomena with abstract constructs that encompass many specific instances of those phenomena. All theories, including TMT, do this. The TMT approach is different in that rather than trying to reduce the pursuit of meaning, certainty, or social connections to a specific instance of death denial, TMT posits that the fear of death affects the way other psychological needs function and the outcomes that will satisfy them. We now consider some of the most influential of these alternatives and explain why they are problematic.

#### *Death Undermines Meaning*

According to the meaning-maintenance model (MMM; Heine et al., 2006), “meaning is the expected relationships or associations that human beings construct and impose on their worlds ... meaning is what connects things to other things in expected ways—anything and any way that things can be connected” (p. 90). The MMM posits that “Humans find it problematic to be ... confronted with meaninglessness, and therefore seek to reconstruct a sense of meaning whenever their meaning frameworks are disrupted” (p. 90). This recapitulates ideas shared by virtually all psychological theories of human thought and reasoning (e.g., Bruner & Taiguri, 1954; Heider, 1958; Kruglanski, 1989). To this widely held assumption, the authors add a fluid compensation model whereby threats to meaning frameworks lead people to bolster and reaffirm other meaning frameworks that remain intact.

From the perspective of the MMM, the reason thoughts of death motivate people to cling to their cultural worldviews, self-esteem, and close attachments is that death undermines meaning. Heine et al. (2006) argue that “people primarily have anxieties about death because death renders life meaningless by severing individuals from their external environment, and in a sense, from themselves” (p. 98). Accordingly, although the problem of death may be especially disturbing, it is not fundamentally different from any other threat to meaning. This is perhaps best illustrated in a study by Proulx and Heine (2008), in which they compared the effect of death reminders with that of subtly replacing an experimenter with another person in a way that their participants did not notice. Intriguingly, these two inductions produced similar effects on moral-belief affirmation, measured by asking participants to set a bond for a prostitute as if they were a judge reviewing the case. This and other findings of meaning-related threats producing effects similar to mortality salience are interpreted as supporting the claim that the problem of death is simply a specific type of threat to meaning.

The most basic problem with this analysis is that knowing one will die is itself a meaning. Consistent with Heine et al.'s definition of meaning, it is an "expected relationship ... (that) connects things to other things in expected ways" (2006, p. 90). If meanings entail "anything and any way that things can be connected" (p. 90), is the fact that life will end someday not a meaning? Indeed, the idea that death entails complete and total annihilation of the self, which is the meaning of death that TMT posits as most troublesome, is also a meaningful relation between things in the world. Clearly, it is not a very pleasant meaning, but it fits the MMM definition of meaning, and therefore it should not be troublesome from that perspective.

Heine et al. (2006) also argue, following Baumeister (1991), that death threatens meaning because: "(a) death undermines the predictability and controllability of one's existence, (b) death eliminates all potential that one has for earning meaning in the future, (c) death reminds people that their existence and the meaning framework that they have constructed will likely be forgotten, and (d) death nullifies the value of one's life's achievements." But if what is important for meaning is how an event fits in with the relationship between ideas and events that one uses to understand the world, physical death would not pose any of the above problems for people who believe in an afterlife, especially the more popular kinds in which life after death far outshines anything one could experience or even imagine during one's physical existence. The ideas about literal immortality that are part of virtually all religions provide clear ways of predicting and controlling one's existence after death, imbue one's future with great cosmic significance and meaning, enshrine people's meaning systems and selves in perpetuity, and provide a crowning achievement of one's life – attaining one's eternal reward. To the extent that death is threatening because it challenges people's existing meaning systems, it should not be troubling to the approximately 75% of today's Americans who believe in life after death (Pew

Research Center, 2010). If one believes in an afterlife, the meaning of death is simply a move to a new, presumably vastly improved environment, and no disconnect from one's self.

We agree with the MMM view that meaning is strongly desired and that the absence of it sets in motion a host of behaviors aimed at restoring it. Yet the TMT perspective diverges from MMM in viewing death as a unique threat that changes the quality and intensity of the pursuit of meaning. Meaning has both epistemic and existential functions. In a deathless world, people would still seek meaning and comprehensibility for purely pragmatic reasons, as a basis for controlling and manipulating their environment. But illusory meanings that deviated from observable reality that were frequently challenged by disconfirming evidence would soon lose their appeal. The practical utility of meaning (the need for accuracy) would be much more potent and the soothing balm of unverifiable meanings would lose much of its power without the ultimate threat of death.

### *Death Undermines Certainty*

In a related vein, uncertainty management theory (UMT; van den Bos, Poortvliet, Maas, Miedema, & van den Ham, 2005; see also McGregor, et al., 2001) argues that death is motivating, at least some of the time, because of the uncertainties it entails: when and how it will happen and what happens afterwards. More recently, van den Bos (2009, p. 198) distinguished between *informational uncertainty*, which is the type of uncertainty studied by decision theorists, which “involves having less information available than one ideally would like to have in order to be able to confidently form a given social judgment,” and *personal uncertainty*, which he defines as “a subjective sense of doubt or instability in self-views, worldviews, or the interrelation between the two” which “involves the implicit and explicit feelings and other subjective reactions people experience as a result of being uncertain about themselves.” UMT views the

personal form of uncertainty as most relevant to worldview defense and existential meaning.

This shift from a relatively undifferentiated concept of uncertainty in early presentations of these ideas (van den Bos & Miedema, 2000) to the focus on uncertainty about self and worldview in more recent presentations (van den Bos, 2009), suggests that UMT views threats to the psychological structures that TMT posits protect people from death-related fear as most threatening. Like the MMM, UMT posits that such threats lead to fluid compensation whereby people cope with threats to one aspect of worldview or self by bolstering unrelated aspects. This seems to imply that these various meanings or certainties regarding self and world serve a shared function of some sort, a view shared with TMT. But UMT and the MMM, unlike TMT, argue that meaning and certainty about self and world are sought only for their own sake and that death is problematic because it undermines these meanings and certainties.

McGregor, Nash, Mann, and Phills (2010) recently advanced a similar concept, *anxious uncertainty*, which like van den Bos' (2009) concept of personal uncertainty is distinguished from "merely informational uncertainty that does not threaten personal goals or cause anxious or ideological reactions in the threat and defense literature." Anxious uncertainty arises from simultaneously active approach and avoidance impulses and activates *reactive approach motivation (RAM)*. From this perspective, tenacious absorption in an alternative approach goal distracts from the anxiety produced by the initial approach-avoidance conflict and thereby reduces the distress of anxious uncertainty. Presumably, virtually any goal or ideal can relieve anxious uncertainty as long as it is sufficiently compelling – thus people pursue these alternative approach goals with intense zeal. Unlike the MMM and UMT, this approach does not posit a common psychological resource that is both undermined by the threat and restored by the defense; in particular, they laud the potential of this framework to dispense with the need for

“convoluted links to the concept of symbolic immortality” (p. 142).

One major problem with McGregor and colleagues’ RAM approach is that the definition of anxious uncertainty is circular: It is not useful to distinguish anxious uncertainty from informational uncertainty by saying that the former is the type that threatens personal goals and causes anxious or ideological reactions. It is also unclear how the fear of death involves a simultaneously active approach and avoidance tendency; as far as we can tell, the fear of death is all about avoidance. The RAM model also leaves out the fact that death reminders increase avoidance motivation, leading to behaviors such as physical distancing from foreigners (Ochsmann & Mathy, 1994), distancing from one’s ethnic group when it is associated with negative qualities (Arndt, Greenberg, Schimel, Pyszczynski, & Solomon, 2002), and increased anxiety when handling cultural icons in a disrespectful manner (Greenberg, Simon, Porteus, Pyszczynski, & Solomon, 1995). Indeed, one of the most widely replicated effects of MS is more negative evaluations of outgroup members and those who criticize one’s worldview, which certainly seems to entail avoidance reactions. Under certain theoretically specified conditions, MS has been shown to lead to avoidance even of things that are normally extremely appealing, such as the physical aspects of sex and other pleasurable physical sensations (Goldenberg, this volume). The fact that most behaviors, including any that involve a choice, can be construed as either approaching one choice or avoiding the other might be used to explain away this problem, but doing so makes it impossible to make precise predictions from this theory: Is derogating an outgroup member approaching one’s own group or avoiding another? Does exercise approach health or avoid illness? It’s also unclear why zealous engagement in an avoidance goal would not provide relief from the anxious uncertainty created by an approach-avoidance conflict.

We agree with UMT that people often crave a sense of certainty. Although we also

recognize that certainty serves other functions, such as increasing the likelihood that one will take action to pursue one's goals, we argue that certainty fulfills an important terror management function. One's worldview, self-esteem, and attachments are only effective in providing protection from existential fears when people hold them with confidence and certainty.

In our view, one of the major problems with all existing alternatives to TMT is that their proponents seem to focus on only the mortality salience hypothesis, rather than the TMT literature in its totality or the real world behavioral phenomena that TMT aims to explain. TMT was not developed to explain why mortality salience produces diverse effects in laboratory studies; rather it was designed to explain why people need self-esteem, faith (or certainty) in their worldviews, and other people to support these two psychological entities. It was also designed with the hope of shedding light on the role that human awareness of the inevitability of death plays in diverse forms of human behavior, an issue that with very few exceptions, was ignored in previous psychological theorizing. The mortality salience hypothesis is simply one of several distinct hypotheses deduced from the theory to guide empirical research on it. A viable alternative to TMT would need to address the questions that TMT tries to answer as well as explain the findings across the diverse hypotheses and applications that have been used to test it. We have never argued that understanding the death-denying aspects of self-esteem, culture, attachment, interpersonal relations, morality, or religion is all that needs to be known about these topics. Rather, we argue that it is impossible to fully understand these issues without a consideration of the role they play in shielding people from the existential terror that results from awareness of the inevitability of death.

### *Concluding Remarks*

The point of this chapter is that human awareness of the inevitability of death changes everything. Specifically, we argued that the dawning awareness of mortality had a unique impact on human psychology that changed why and how humans relate to meaning systems such as ideology, morality, and religion. We argued that the zeal and dedication with which people cling to these aspects of their culture, especially the resistance of such beliefs to compelling evidence that challenges the basis for these meanings, cannot be explained by rational or pragmatic forces alone. We emphasized the urgency and unique direction that death anxiety adds to human motivation. Despite abiding perceptions about death anxiety bringing out the worst in people, recent TMT research has made it increasingly clear that this is not true. We believe that further research on how people can use their awareness of death as a source of meaning and growth instead of a source of paralyzing dread and ultimately harmful defenses is needed, and we hope to see future TMT research move in that direction.

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### *Notes*

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